



Mob rule in Illinois

A contemporary engraving shows the attack on the warehouse in Alton where abolitionist Elijah Lovejoy had hidden his printing press. In the riot, Lovejoy was fatally wounded by five bullets and the press destroyed.

Political anti-slavery

Throughout the 1840s and 1850s, many Northerners grew increasingly opposed to the spread of slavery. These anti-slavery supporters did not necessarily advocate emancipation. Often hostile to Southern interests, many were simply opposed to the existence of more slave states. Some used anti-slavery as a way of playing the political system, running candidates, and seeking office. Garrison and his followers rejected any political activity as corrupt, while others such as Frederick Douglass were suspicious of the absence of concern for Black rights. Events of the 1850s would move radical ideas about slavery into the political mainstream in the North, a gradual shift observed by Southerners with anger and alarm.